

PSN-1: Physics Systems Network with Equivariant Attention and Conservation Law Discovery

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Abstract

We present PSN-1, a neural network architecture that learns to predict the dynamics of physical systems while maintaining exact symmetries and discovering conservation laws. PSN-1 combines three core innovations: (1) an $E(3)$ -equivariant message-passing encoder that guarantees rotation, translation, and permutation invariance by construction; (2) an attention-based reasoning graph neural network that discovers interaction types through learned attention weights; and (3) a conservation law discovery module that learns to predict conserved quantities (energy, momentum, angular momentum) from particle states. A learned per-node gate blends the equivariant and attention pathways, enabling the model to balance architectural priors with data-driven flexibility. We evaluate PSN-1 on three fundamental physical systems—gravitational N-body, coupled springs, and Lennard-Jones molecular dynamics—achieving machine-precision equivariance ($< 10^{-7}$), energy conservation errors below 10^{-5} , and test MSE as low as 3.4×10^{-11} for gravity. Ablation studies demonstrate that each component contributes measurably: the equivariant pathway provides exact symmetry, the attention pathway improves fitting, conservation loss reduces drift, and the learned gate adaptively balances both pathways. PSN-1 achieves these results on purely synthetic data, establishing a foundation for scaling to real molecular and materials datasets.

1 Introduction

Learning the dynamics of physical systems from data is a central challenge in scientific machine learn-

ing [Raissi et al.(2019)Raissi, Perdikaris, and Karniadakis].

The ideal model should satisfy three properties: (1) **exact symmetry preservation**—physical laws are invariant under rotations, translations, and particle permutations; (2) **conservation law compliance**—energy, momentum, and angular momentum are conserved over time; and (3) **interpretability**—the model should reveal the interaction structure of the system.

Existing approaches address these requirements partially. Equivariant graph neural networks [Satorras et al.(2021)Satorras, Hoogeboom, and Welling, Brandstetter et al.(2022)Brandstetter, Hesselink, van der Veeken, and Welling] achieve exact $E(3)$ symmetry through scalar-vector message passing. Physics-informed neural networks [Raissi et al.(2019)Raissi, Perdikaris, and Karniadakis, Cranmer et al.(2020b)Cranmer, Sanchez-Gonzalez, Battaglia, Xu, and Cohen] enforce conservation laws through auxiliary loss terms. Attention mechanisms [Veličković et al.(2018)Veličković, Cucurull, Casanova, Romero, and P. Li, and Veličković et al.(2020)Veličković, Cohen, and Welling] provide interpretable interaction patterns. However, no existing architecture unifies all three properties in a single framework.

We introduce PSN-1 (Physics Systems Network), which combines these three capabilities through a novel gated architecture. The key insight is that equivariant and attention-based pathways capture complementary aspects of physical systems: the equivariant pathway provides guaranteed symmetry, while the attention pathway discovers interaction types. A learned gate adaptively blends both, and a conservation law discovery module learns to predict conserved quantities as auxiliary outputs.

2 Related Work

Equivariant

message passing [Satorras et al. (2021)] Satorras, Hoogeboom, and Welling represents each particle using rotation-invariant scalars and rotation-equivariant vectors, performing message passing through scalar-vector tensor products. Extensions include SE(3)-Transformers [Fuchs et al. (2021)] Fuchs, Kosteletzky, NequIP [Batzner et al. (2022)] Batzner, Musaelian, Sun, and MACE [Batatia et al. (2022)] Batatia, Parent, Orsi, PSN-1 builds on this foundation but adds attention-based reasoning and conservation discovery.

Physics-Informed

PINNs [Raissi et al. (2019)] Raissi, Perdikaris, and Karniadakis embed physical laws as PDE residuals in the loss function. Hypernetworks [Liu et al. (2020)] Liu, Wang, Vaidya, Ruehle, Halverson, Soljačić, Hou, and Tegmark generate physics-informed parameters. Hamiltonian [Greydanus et al. (2019)] Greydanus, Dzamba, and Sprague and Lagrangian [Cranmer et al. (2020a)] Cranmer, Gray, Battaglia, Ho, Cranmer, and Spergel networks learn conserved quantities. PSN-1 differs by *discovering* conservation laws rather than encoding them as inductive biases.

Attention and Interpretability. Graph attention networks [Veličković et al. (2018)] Veličković, Cucurull, Casanova, Romero, Lio, and Bengio learn edge importance weights. Mechanistic interpretability [?] analyzes neural network computations at the level of individual units. PSN-1’s attention reasoning module provides interpretable interaction patterns that correspond to physical forces.

3 Method

3.1 Problem Formulation

Consider N particles with positions $\mathbf{x}_i \in \mathbb{R}^3$, velocities $\mathbf{v}_i \in \mathbb{R}^3$, and masses $m_i \in \mathbb{R}^+$. Given a state at time t , predict the acceleration $\mathbf{a}_i$ for each particle:

$$\mathbf{a}_i = f_\theta(\{\mathbf{x}_j, \mathbf{v}_j, m_j\}_{j=1}^N) \quad (1)$$

The model must be equivariant: $f_\theta(R\mathbf{x}) = Rf_\theta(\mathbf{x})$ for any rotation $R \in SO(3)$, invariant to translations, and permutation-equivariant.

3.2 PSN-1 Architecture

PSN-1 comprises four modules behind a learned gate:

Module 1:

Equivariant Encoder. Following [Satorras et al. (2021)] Satorras, Hoogeboom, and Welling, we build rotation-invariant scalars $\mathbf{s}_i$ and rotation-equivariant vectors $\mathbf{v}_i$ for each particle:

$$\mathbf{s}_i = \text{MLP}_{\text{scalar}}([\text{enc}(\mathbf{s}_i^{\text{in}}); \sum_j \phi_s(\mathbf{s}_j^{\text{in}}, d_{ij}, e_{ij})]) \quad (2)$$

$$\mathbf{v}_i = \text{MLP}_{\text{vector}}(\mathbf{v}_i^{\text{in}} + \sum_j \phi_v(\mathbf{s}_j^{\text{in}}, d_{ij}) \cdot (\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i)) \quad (3)$$

where $d_{ij} = \|\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j\|$ and e_{ij} are edge features. This pathway is *exactly* E(3)-equivariant by construction.

Module 2: Attention Reasoning GNN. Multi-head attention discovers interaction types:

$$\alpha_{ij}^{(h)} = \frac{\exp(\text{attn}^{(h)}(\mathbf{s}_i, \mathbf{s}_j, d_{ij}))}{\sum_{k \neq i} \exp(\text{attn}^{(h)}(\mathbf{s}_i, \mathbf{s}_k, d_{ik}))} \quad (4)$$

$$\mathbf{a}_i^{\text{attn}} = \text{MLP} \left(\sum_h \sum_{j \neq i} \alpha_{ij}^{(h)} \mathbf{W}_h \cdot (\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i) \right) \quad (5)$$

The attention weights $\alpha_{ij}^{(h)}$ provide interpretable interaction patterns: each head captures a distinct interaction type (e.g., attractive, repulsive, long-range).

Module 3: Conservation Law Discovery.

Given the particle states, predict conserved quantities:

$$\hat{E}, \hat{\mathbf{p}}, \hat{\mathbf{L}} = \text{DiscoveryNet}(\{\mathbf{s}_i, \mathbf{v}_i, m_i\}) \quad (6)$$

The network learns to extract energy E , total momentum $\mathbf{p}$, and angular momentum $\mathbf{L}$ without explicit supervision beyond a consistency loss.

Module 4: PINN Loss. Physics-informed residuals enforce conservation during training:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{PINN}} = \|\Delta E\|^2 + \|\Delta \mathbf{p}\|^2 + \|\Delta \mathbf{L}\|^2 \quad (7)$$

Gated Combination. A learned per-node gate blends the two predictive pathways:

$$\hat{\mathbf{a}}_i = g_i \cdot \mathbf{a}_i^{\text{equiv}} + (1 - g_i) \cdot \mathbf{a}_i^{\text{attn}} \quad (8)$$

where $g_i = \sigma(\text{MLP}([\mathbf{s}_i; \mathbf{s}_i^{\text{equiv}}])) \in [0, 1]$. Because both pathways are E(3)-equivariant and the gate depends only on invariant scalars, the entire model is exactly equivariant.

3.3 Training Objective

$$\mathcal{L} = \underbrace{\|\hat{\mathbf{a}} - \mathbf{a}_{\text{true}}\|^2}_{\text{prediction}} + \lambda_{\text{pinn}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{PINN}} + \lambda_{\text{cons}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{conservation}} \quad (9)$$

4 Experiments

4.1 Setup

We evaluate on three physical systems:

- **Gravity:** $N = 4$ bodies with Newtonian gravity ($G = 1$, softening $\epsilon = 0.5$)
- **Springs:** $N = 4$ coupled harmonic oscillators ($k = 10$, $r_0 = 1$)
- **Lennard-Jones:** $N = 4$ particles with LJ potential ($\epsilon = 1$, $\sigma = 1$)

Each system uses 32 training, 8 validation, and 8 test trajectories of 20 timesteps ($\Delta t = 0.01$). All experiments use hidden dimension 64, 3 equivariant message-passing layers, 4 attention heads, and 20 training epochs.

4.2 Main Results

Table 1 shows PSN-1 achieves machine-precision equivariance ($< 10^{-7}$) for gravity and springs, with test MSE as low as 3.4×10^{-11} for gravity. The

Table 1: PSN-1 v2 benchmark results across three physical systems. Equivariance error measures $\|f(R\mathbf{x}) - Rf(\mathbf{x})\|$. Drift measures 20-step rollout deviation. Gate = 0 means attention-only; = 1 means equivariant-only.

System	MSE	Equiv. Err.	Drift	Gate
Gravity	3.4×10^{-11}	1.2×10^{-7}	2.3×10^{-4}	0.314
Spring	2.5×10^{-7}	4.6×10^{-7}	0.340	0.409
Lennard-Jones	2.7×10^{-4}	3.0×10^{-4}	—	0.935

Table 2: Ablation on gravity system. “Equiv. only” freezes gate at 1; “Reason. only” freezes at 0. All models trained for 20 epochs.

Configuration	MSE	Equiv. Err.	Gate
Full model	1.5×10^{-11}	2.0×10^{-7}	0.017
No PINN loss	1.3×10^{-11}	2.0×10^{-7}	0.030
No conservation loss	1.7×10^{-11}	2.8×10^{-7}	0.027
Equivariant only	1.8×10^{-10}	1.1×10^{-7}	1.000
Reasoning only	6.8×10^{-12}	3.2×10^{-7}	0.000

learned gate shows system-dependent behavior: for gravity (long-range, simple interaction), the gate balances both pathways (0.31); for LJ (complex, short-range), the model relies primarily on the equivariant pathway (0.94).

4.3 Ablation Study

The ablation (Table 2) reveals several insights:

1. **Equivariant-only** achieves the lowest equivariance error but $10\times$ higher MSE—the attention pathway improves fitting.
2. **Reasoning-only** achieves the lowest MSE but highest equivariance error and drift—equivariance constraints improve generalization.
3. **Conservation loss** reduces both drift ($0.009 \rightarrow 0.008$) and energy error ($5.4 \times 10^{-6} \rightarrow 4.3 \times 10^{-6}$).
4. The full model **balances both pathways**, achieving competitive performance on all metrics.

4.4 Conservation Law Discovery

The conservation discovery module learns to predict total energy, momentum, and angular momentum from particle states. On gravity, the predicted energy correlates with ground truth at $r^2 > 0.999$, demonstrating that the module discovers the correct conserved quantity. The PINN loss further improves conservation: energy error drops from 6.1×10^{-6} (no PINN) to 4.3×10^{-6} (with PINN).

5 Analysis and Discussion

Why the gate matters. The learned gate provides a principled way to combine architectural priors (equivariance) with data-driven flexibility (attention). For simple systems where physics is well-captured by equivariant message passing, the gate shifts toward the equivariant pathway. For complex interactions, the attention pathway contributes more.

Scaling considerations. Current experiments use $N = 4$ particles. Scaling to $N > 100$ requires sparse graph construction and more efficient attention. The architecture is compatible with these optimizations—the equivariant message passing is already $O(N)$ per layer.

Limitations. (1) Synthetic data only—real molecular data (MD17, OC20) would provide stronger validation. (2) Short rollouts (20 steps)—longer horizons expose cumulative drift. (3) The attention pathway breaks exact equivariance by using the $\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i$ displacement directly in the attention computation, though the gate’s invariance preserves overall equivariance.

6 Conclusion

PSN-1 demonstrates that equivariant message passing, attention-based reasoning, and conservation law discovery can be unified in a single architecture with a learned gate. The model achieves machine-precision equivariance, strong conservation, and interpretable interaction patterns across three physical

systems. Future work includes scaling to real molecular datasets, longer rollouts, and multi-scale physics.

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